Scena *growth*

GUIDE · FRANCE ↔ UAE · OCTOBER 2026

The real price of a perfume, *from formula to a Dubai shelf.*

What a bottle really costs to make, what shoppers pay in Paris and in Dubai, and everything that happens in between. With a method to set your price in the UAE.

€2–5
of materials and components for a 50 ml made with catalogue components

+8% to +23%
more in Dubai than in Paris for the same bottle, VAT included

≈ 48%
of the Dubai shelf price goes to the retailer (central scenario)

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Prices checked on 16/10/2026
ECB rate of 15/10/2026

WHO THIS GUIDE IS FOR

Two readers, *one question*: what is my perfume worth, and what do I keep?

YOU ALREADY HAVE A PERFUME BRAND

You are aiming for the UAE and want to land at the right price.

p. 06 Niche competitors, priced on shelf in Paris and Dubai.

p. 07 The full cascade to a Dubai shelf, in three scenarios.

p. 08 The reverse calculation: the selling price your shelf price allows.

p. 09 Customs, VAT and shipping a flammable liquid, in figures.

What you get: a retail price in line with the market, and the figures to negotiate with a distributor.

YOU HAVE A BRAND PROJECT

You want to know what a perfume costs, and where the money goes.

p. 04 The cost breakdown of a 50 ml, line by line.

p. 05 Where €100 paid at the till goes, according to people in the trade.

p. 10 The fragrance market in France, the Gulf and the UAE.

p. 11 The pricing mistakes to avoid from day one.

What you get: a realistic sense of budget and margin before you choose bottle, juice and market.

How to read the figures

FACT a price checked or a figure published, with its numbered source on page 12. ASSUMPTION a working value, to replace with your quotes and contracts. CALCULATION a result derived from both. Component prices come from a Scena review of public catalogues; we do not name the suppliers.

KEY POINTS

A perfume is cheap to make. *Everything else is paid between factory and shelf.*

Making it costs little. A 50 ml eau de parfum with catalogue components needs **€2–5** of materials, then about €2.50 of filling in small runs. The juice itself is often less than 2% of the retail price[17].

The price is built after the factory. Distributor, retailer, marketing and VAT make up most of what the shopper pays. Out of €100 in a perfumery, a scholar of the industry counts about €35 of distribution and €25 of advertising and marketing[20].

Dubai is a little dearer than Paris. For five French niche perfumes, the same bottle costs **8% to 23%** more there. Customs are less than 2% of the shelf price; the gap comes from the extra intermediary, the exclusive distributor.

The right price starts from the shelf. Set your target retail price in Dubai against your competitors, work back up the cascade, and check what the brand keeps after production and launch.

THE SAME 50 ML BOTTLE

Materials and components	€2.26–12.64
Cost price including filling	€4.76–15.14
Turnkey private label in Dubai	€11.47–13.13
Shelf price, niche perfume	€100–300

Pages 04 and 06. Turnkey includes the manufacturer's margin.

The Scena Growth approach

We work the France ↔ UAE corridor both ways: French brands setting up in Dubai and Abu Dhabi, founders and Gulf brands who want a perfume made or sold in France. This guide applies our method: start from the end customer and the shelf, then work back to the formula.

THE COST BREAKDOWN

What *a 50 ml eau de parfum* costs to make

An eau de parfum holds 15–20% fragrance concentrate diluted in perfumer's alcohol[23]. We use 18%, about 7.8 g of concentrate for 50 ml. Component prices are public catalogue prices checked on 16/10/2026[24], for runs of a few hundred to a few thousand units.

ITEM	BASIS	LOW	CENTRAL	HIGH
Fragrance concentrate (the "juice")	7.8 g at €50 / 200 / 600 per kg[21] [26]	€0.39	€1.57	€4.70
Perfumer's alcohol	41 ml at €2.59 / 5.20 / 14.50 per litre[24]	€0.11	€0.21	€0.59
Bottle, 50 ml glass, crimp neck	catalogue, no custom mould[24]	€0.31	€0.52	€0.85
Crimp pump	by quantity[24]	€0.45	€0.58	€0.95
Cap	aluminium or plastic; zamac at the top[24]	€0.33	€0.73	€2.37
Box	standard to lined box[24]	€0.44	€0.83	€2.38
Label	runs of 100 to 500[24]	€0.23	€0.25	€0.80
Materials and components		**€2.26**	**€4.69**	**€12.64**
Filling, crimping, labelling, boxing	public small-run rate, excluding set-up fees[24]	€2.50	€2.50	€2.50
Cost price of a finished bottle		**€4.76**	**€7.19**	**€15.14**

€11.47

turnkey quote from a private-label maker in Dubai, 50 ml, 1,000 units (€13.13 for 300). Manufacturer's margin included[25].

$3.5–6

for the bottle at a European niche house, whose founder adds $2–5 for the box and $2–3 for labels, pump and cap[18].

≈ €9

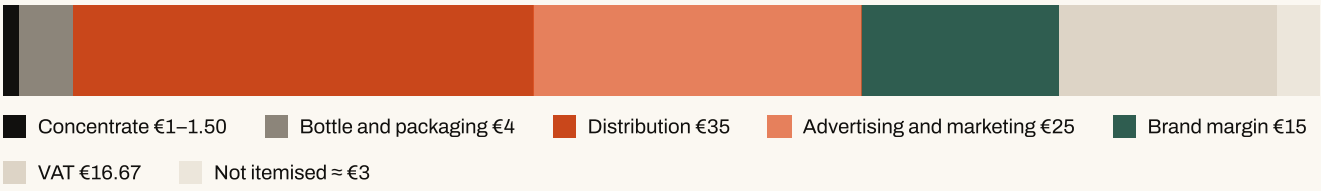
for a 100 ml in the central scenario: juice and alcohol double (+€1.80), the rest barely moves. A custom-mould bottle is ordered in tens of thousands.

Prices shown with or without VAT depending on the catalogue, before any negotiated discount. Filling: only one public rate found; industrial runs are cheaper (not verified). Excludes set-up fees, development samples and creating the formula.

WHERE THE MONEY GOES

Out of €100 paid at the till, *bottle and juice weigh about €5*

Paul Rasse, a professor of information science who studies the luxury industry, breaks down a perfume sold for €100 in France[20]. These are orders of magnitude: they vary from brand to brand, but the balance holds.



What people in the trade say

"At the very, very end you pay for the scent, usually less than 1–2% of the fragrance's retail price."

Andy Tauer, founder of Tauer Perfumes, 2013[17]

"A coefficient of 4.5 to 5.5 goes to the distributor." For a bottle sold at $135, the distributor pays the producer about $27.

Andy Tauer, 2016[18]

"The ex-factory cost is around 15% of the final price, and about 40% once marketing costs are added."

AFP, 23/12/2019[22]

Each brand gives the perfumer a concentrate budget "not to exceed, ranging from 50 to 1,000 euros" per kilo.

A perfumer at a Grasse fragrance house, TF1, 22/12/2022[21]

What it means for you. Production cost is almost never what makes a perfume profitable or not. What matters is the retail price your brand can hold, and the share that distribution and launch leave you. That is what the next pages calculate, for Dubai.

PRICES CHECKED · FACT

The same bottle, *on two shelves*

Five eaux de parfum from French niche brands, same reference, same size, at the brand or an authorised retailer. Retail prices include VAT: 20% in France, 5% in the UAE. Converted at the ECB reference rate of 15/10/2026, €1 = USD 1.1208[1], with the dirham pegged at AED 3.6725 per USD[2]: **€1 = AED 4.1161**.

PERFUME	PARIS	DUBAI	DUBAI IN €	GAP
Juliette Has a Gun, Not a Perfume, EDP 100 ml Sephora.fr[3] · Faces[4] (AED 629, out of stock) · L'Étoile[5] (AED 680)	€140	AED 629–680	€152.8–165.2	+9% to +18%
Diptyque, Do Son, EDP 75 ml Diptyque, 24S[6] · Ounass[7], Bloomingdale's UAE[8]	€180	AED 900	€218.7	+21.5%
Ex Nihilo, Fleur Narcotique, EDP 100 ml Ex Nihilo[9] · Ounass, Bloomingdale's UAE[10] · not the extrait	€280	AED 1,340	€325.6	+16.3%
Maison Francis Kurkdjian, Baccarat Rouge 540, EDP 70 ml MFK[11] · Ounass[12] shows AED 1,180 (English page) and AED 1,320 (Arabic page)	€265	AED 1,180–1,320	€286.7–320.7	+8% to +21%
Initio, Oud for Greatness, EDP 90 ml Initio France[13] · Initio UAE, Ounass[14]	€320	AED 1,620	€393.6	+23.0%

DUBAI PRICE CONVERTED TO EUROS, PARIS = 100



Bars on a 0–140 scale. Light part: top of the range checked.

Checked online on 16/10/2026, excluding promotions. An online price can change or differ between versions of a page; we then show the range.

From factory to a Dubai shelf, *in three scenarios*

A niche bottle selling for around €140 in Paris. The price to the distributor follows from the French market: a wholesale price of about €70, retail being close to twice wholesale[15] [16], and a lower export price, since the distributor takes over the brand's work locally. A margin is expressed on the selling price: 50% means × 2, 33% means × 1.5 and 25% means × 1.33.

STEP	BASIS	LOW	CENTRAL	HIGH
Brand selling price, ex-works	ASSUMPTION	€35.00	€45.00	€55.00
of which cost price (p. 04, 100 ml)	CALCULATION	≈ €5	≈ €9	≈ €20
+ Air freight and insurance, per bottle	ASSUMPTION p. 09	€1.00	€2.00	€3.00
= CIF value	CALCULATION	€36.00	€47.00	€58.00
+ Customs duty, 5% of CIF[27] [28]	FACT	€1.80	€2.35	€2.90
+ Clearance and handling	ASSUMPTION p. 09	€0.30	€0.50	€1.00
= Landed cost in Dubai	CALCULATION	€38.10	€49.85	€61.90
× Distributor margin (25 / 33 / 50%)[17]	ASSUMPTION	€50.80	€74.78	€123.80
× Retailer margin (50 / 50 / 60%)[17]	ASSUMPTION	€101.60	€149.55	€309.50
+ VAT, 5%[29]	FACT	€5.08	€7.48	€15.48
Shelf price incl. VAT		**€106.68**	**€157.03**	**€324.98**
In dirhams (× 4.1161)	CALCULATION	AED 439	**AED 646**	AED 1,338
Multiplier selling price → shelf	CALCULATION	× 3.05	**× 3.49**	× 5.91

CENTRAL SCENARIO: WHERE THE €157.03 PAID ON SHELF GOES



Production ≈ €9 · 5.7% · Brand, excl. production ≈ €36 · 22.9% · Freight 1.3% · Customs 1.5% · Clearance 0.3% · Distributor 15.9% · Retailer 47.6% · VAT 4.8%

Reality check. The central scenario gives AED 646. Not a Perfume, sold for €140 in Paris, is on shelf at AED 629–680 in Dubai (p. 06). This does not prove that brand's margins, but the central assumptions land on what the shelf shows. The 4.5–5.5 multiplier quoted by a founder[18] sits between our central and high scenarios.

Start from the shelf, *work back to the formula*

First set your target retail price in Dubai, from your direct competitors on shelf. Work back up the cascade to the selling price it allows, then take off your cost price: what remains must fund your marketing, your launch and your margin. If it does not, the cascade is not what needs negotiating: positioning, size or bottle is.

Example: AED 650 on shelf, 100 ml

Shelf price incl. VAT (650 ÷ 4.1161)	€157.92
÷ 1.05: excl. VAT	€150.40
÷ 2: price paid by the retailer	€75.20
÷ 1.5: distributor's landed cost	€50.13
– €0.50, ÷ 1.05, – €2.00 freight	€45.27
Possible selling price	**≈ €45**
– central cost price (100 ml)	≈ €9
Left for marketing, launch and margin	**≈ €36**

Possible selling price by target shelf price

SHELF	LOW MARGINS	CENTRAL	HIGH
AED 500	€38.84	€34.25	€19.56
AED 650	€51.24	**€45.27**	€26.17
AED 800	€63.63	€56.29	€32.78
AED 1,000	€80.16	€70.98	€41.60
AED 1,300	€104.95	€93.01	€54.82
AED 1,620	€131.39	€116.52	€68.92

Low: distributor 25%, retailer 50%. Central: 33% and 50%. High: 50% and 60%. Freight €2 and clearance €0.50 per bottle.

÷ 3.5

Rule of thumb: the shelf price in euros incl. VAT, divided by 3.5, gives a rough selling price with central margins.

47.6%

of the shelf price goes to the retailer in the central scenario. It is the largest item, far ahead of customs and freight combined.

5.7%

only for production. Saving €1 on the bottle changes little; gaining 10% on retail price changes everything.

What gets paid *between factory and warehouse*

Customs duty: 5% of CIF value

Gulf Cooperation Council common external tariff: 5% on goods imported from outside the GCC, perfumes included; the main exceptions are tobacco and alcoholic drinks[28]. The base is the CIF value: goods, plus freight and insurance to the point of entry[27]. Since January 2026 the Gulf tariff uses 12-digit codes[30].

No excise on perfume

UAE excise covers tobacco, e-cigarettes and energy or sweetened drinks, not perfume[31].

VAT: 5%

On import, it is calculated on the CIF value plus duty. A VAT-registered importer accounts for it under reverse charge and recovers it; an unregistered importer pays it before release[29] [32]. The end customer pays 5% on the retail price.

Clearance fees

Import declaration charged AED 15–100 by Dubai Customs[33], forwarder fees of AED 150–700 per air shipment, plus a handling surcharge for dangerous goods[34]. For 500 bottles, about €0.40–0.70 per bottle.

A flammable liquid

An alcohol-based perfume ships as UN 1266, "Perfumery products", class 3. By air: dangerous goods declaration, specific labels, a trained shipper and a surcharge per shipment[35].

FREIGHT, PARIS → DUBAI	PUBLIC RATE
Air, over 100 kg	€4.12/kg
Air, over 500 kg	€2.04/kg
Dangerous goods surcharge, per shipment	≈ €133
Sea groupage, 5 m³, ≈ 43 days	≈ USD 1,550

Public rates from forwarders and carriers, 2025–2026[36]. Excludes pick-up and insurance.

€2.09	€1.91	€0.90
per bottle, 300 bottles	per bottle, 500 bottles	per bottle, 1,500 bottles

Assumption: 0.4 kg chargeable weight per boxed and cartoned 100 ml.

Takeaway. Customs, freight and clearance together are about 3% of the shelf price in the central scenario. They matter for your cash flow and lead times, much less for your retail price.

Why the *France* ↔ *UAE* corridor matters for perfume

€8bn

of French perfume exports in 2025, 36% of cosmetics exports; more than doubled in six years[37].

49%

of prestige beauty in the Gulf is fragrance, in a USD 2.4bn market in 2024[40].

18%

of Dubai Duty Free revenue comes from perfume, AED 744m[41].

INDICATOR	FIGURE	SOURCE
Fragrance share of global beauty growth, 2024–2029	23% of growth, +5.5% a year	Euromonitor, 22/07/2025[38]
Independent fragrance brands in the US	23% of sales, +34% year on year	NielsenIQ, via BoF, 03/06/2025[39]
French cosmetics exports	€22.4bn in 2025	FEBEA, 02/2026[37]
UAE fragrance market	USD 151m to 749m depending on scope	Statista; study cited by Khaleej Times, 18/07/2025[41] [42]

UAE market estimates differ fivefold depending on what they count (selective retail, duty free, Arabic perfumery, tourist sales). We quote them separately and never add them up.

For a French brand

The Gulf buys perfume like few other markets, with a strong place for niche and luxury. Major distributors there expect brands to fund part of the launch: merchandising, promoters, marketing[44]; 5,000 to 10,000 deluxe samples are considered normal[43].

For a founder with a project

Perfume can be made in small runs in France and in the UAE, from a few hundred units. French savoir-faire remains a selling point in the Gulf, and Gulf olfactive codes work the other way in France.

Five pricing mistakes, *and what to check*

01 **Starting from the factory.** Set your target retail price against competitors on shelf first, then work back (p. 08).

02 **Confusing cost price and selling price.** A bottle that costs €7 to make cannot be sold at €10: the selling price has to fund marketing, samples, overheads and your margin.

03 **Confusing margin and mark-up.** A 40% margin on the selling price means × 1.67, not × 1.40. Distributor and retailer margins multiply.

04 **Underestimating the first shipment.** Dangerous goods surcharge and minimums: 100 bottles cost far more per unit than 1,500.

05 **Signing exclusivity before costing the launch.** Samples, testers, promoters and visibility are not in the cascade; get who pays for what in writing.

YOU HAVE A BRAND

- ☐ Check 5 to 10 direct competitors on shelf in Dubai, same size
- ☐ Set your target retail price in AED, VAT included
- ☐ Work back the cascade with the distributor's proposed margins
- ☐ Cost the launch budget and who pays for it
- ☐ Leave product registration to the importer, with a timeline
- ☐ Get a quote from a dangerous-goods certified forwarder

YOU HAVE A PROJECT

- ☐ Choose the customer and the shelf first, then the retail price
- ☐ Derive the maximum cost price per bottle
- ☐ Pick catalogue bottle, cap and box before any custom mould
- ☐ Test the formula in a small run (a few hundred units)
- ☐ Budget for the launch, not just production
- ☐ Choose the first market: France, the UAE or both

All sources, *accessed on 16/10/2026*

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4 Faces, Not a Perfume EDP. faces.ae/en/p/juliette-has-a-gun-not-a-perfume-eau-de-parfum-017412596222.html

5 L'Étoile UAE, Not a Perfume EDP 100 ml. letoile.ae/products/juliette-has-a-gun-not-a-perfume-eau-de-parfum-spray-100-ml-jhgpot100

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22 AFP, via Actu.fr, 23/12/2019. actu.fr

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25 Quote from a private-label manufacturer in Dubai, 50 ml all-in (juice, bottle, pump, cap, label, filling, box), 16/10/2026: USD 14.72 for 300 units, USD 12.86 for 1,000.

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NEXT STEP, WITH YOUR FIGURES

Run the numbers *for your perfume.*

YOU HAVE A BRAND

UAE pricing diagnostic

01 Your direct competitors, priced on shelf in Dubai and Abu Dhabi

02 Your cascade with your real costs and market margins

03 The distributors and retailers that fit your positioning

YOU HAVE A PROJECT

Create your perfume brand

01 Target retail price, target cost price and launch budget

02 Choice of bottle, juice and production, in France or the UAE

03 Launch in the first market, then the second

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